Columbia River High School

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Special Recognition - Naming of a School or Facility
Artificial Turf Field at Columbia River High School

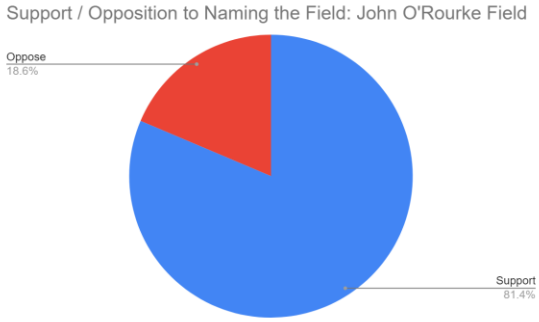
Recommendation from the CRHS Naming Committee
April 15, 2022

A naming committee of Columbia River students, staff members, alumni and parents recommends naming the artificial turf athletic field in honor of John O'Rourke, a longtime Vancouver Public Schools coach and teacher.

O'Rourke, who passed away in November 2021, had a career that spanned nearly five decades at Lewis Junior High and Columbia River High School. He retired from teaching in 2007 but went on to coach until 2015. O'Rourke was league coach of the year nine times and district coach of the year twice. His teams achieved 14 league titles. He was inducted into the Washington state Coaches Hall of Fame in 2012.

The Vancouver community was invited to take part in a survey to name the artificial turf field at Columbia River High School. The survey was open to the public Tuesday, March 22, through Monday, April 11 at 8 p.m. Respondents to the survey were asked to indicate their support for naming the field after O'Rourke, or they were able to suggest other names.

More than 81% of the 215 responses supported the naming of "John O'Rourke Field" at Columbia River High School.



Illustrative comments in support of naming "John O'Rourke Field":

> *I like it when schools and things at schools honor the people who served at those schools.*
> *– Traci H.*

Mr. O'Rourke was my teacher in 1978, Wrestling Coach 1978/1979. John was an amazing individual who impacted thousands of students' lives. Very fitting tribute. – Terry M.

Coach O. had a positive impact on the lives of so many Columbia River students. Coach O. focused on character, community and creating a safe environment for student/athletes to grow. Well after Coach had started with the Vancouver School District, the district decided to create its own set of core values within the athletic department. Those core values are Trust, Integrity and Excellence. Coach O. embodied those values each and every day he came to work. Coach O.'s impact was never more evident than during his celebration of life, in which you saw letterman's jackets from the 80's, 90's and 2000's. All former student athletes paying their respects to a man who had a profound impact on who they are today! – Greg R.

Love the idea - he was just a fantastic influence over so many years! Fully support honoring him!! – Kelli B.

Coach O. was a great man that even though I only had a year to be around was a big influence. – Parker M.

Coach is a legend at River; (he) embodied our core values. – Alicia G.

John worked at CR (for) approximately 35 years. He was the head football coach from 1995 until 2016. He was one of the finest coaches I ever worked with. He was a wonderful person worthy of this honor. – Willie T.

Mr. O'Rourke had a huge positive impact on many students throughout his time at River. Even though I graduated many years ago, I still remember his kindness and ability to connect with students. – Patty K.

I played football under John when he was an offensive coordinator at River. I also was the Public Address Announcer for his football teams at River for 18 of the 22 seasons he was River's head coach. I know that he represented the long-lasting family, school and social values and traditions we all know to be true. While he was called a football coach, he was actually coaching and mentoring life-long learning to all of us who came in contact with him along the way. It would be a great way to honor him and allow us all who knew him to remember his attributes and the person we should all try and be. – Steven H.

I distantly knew Mr. O'Rourke while I was at CRHS and think his incredibly long contribution to and impact on the school deserves to be honored. While River has lost other phenomenal teachers (like Heidi Lohnes Berry), naming the football field specifically after Coach O'Rourke makes the most sense. – Kate L.

John O'Rourke was an icon at Columbia River High School. I had the pleasure of working directly with John for 5 years at CRHS, While I worked with him I saw his commitment to not only coaching for wins but to coach the whole player. He cared about each player as an individual, not just a number on the field. He was tough but fair and held his players to a higher standard in their play and their actions off the field. He was instrumental in student athletes being more successful as productive members of society. – Don L.

After reading the information provided by CRHS and the Obituary of John O'Rourke I felt a sense of "AWE". The amount of time and encouragement John spent with kids, guiding them, teaching them and boosting their selflessness made me feel so humble and proud to have his name be selected as an option for the naming of the Turf Field @ River. We need more people like John, not just teachers, but to spend time with young adults who are still learning to be an adult, learning how to cope and overcome their own battles and just learn to be a better person. Who better than to teach them than someone who has not only lived a full and meaningful life, but someone who is devoted to paying it forward and watching these young men grow into the young men they are meant to be. Not one of these young men will ever be the same. They are their own person, but to know that John had a hand in guiding them down the right path leaves a good legacy to pay forward. – Amanda N.

Coach O'Rourke represented the spirit of what CR stands for. I can't think of a better way to honor him and encourage the community to uphold the values of CRHS. – Evan M.

My wife graduated from CR in 1969 and we have two sons that played football under Coach O'Rourke during which time my wife was very involved in supporting the program. We gained a huge respect for Coach O'Rourke and his influence on the students and athletes at Columbia River High School. Both of our sons are in public service. Our oldest son became a school teacher and always wanted to coach football, no doubt due to Coach O'Rourke's influence, and is now in school administration. Our youngest son is a decorated police officer. I have no doubt that much of their success in serving the better good is in so small part due to Coach O'Rourke's supportive influence during their formative years. – Alan S.

Name options the committee is forwarding for consideration:

Option 1: **John O'Rourke Field**
185 people supported this name.

O'Rourke, who passed away in November 2021, had a career that spanned nearly five decades at Lewis Junior High and Columbia River High School. He retired from teaching in 2007 but went on to coach until 2015. O'Rourke was league coach of the year nine times and district coach of

the year twice. His teams achieved 14 league titles. He was inducted into the Washington state Coaches Hall of Fame in 2012.

Option 2: **Hunter Pearson Field**
Twenty of the 40 people who did not support naming the field after John O'Rourke suggested Hunter Pearson.

Hunter Pearson was a student athlete at Columbia River who died tragically before commencement with the Class of 2017. Since then, Columbia River Football has held the pregame coin toss on the 30 yard line in honor of the number 30 he wore while playing football. The CRHS Naming Committee may consider a recommendation of painting the 30 yard line purple/gold.

Option 3: **Rapids Field**
Two people suggested this name, aligning with the school mascot.

Option 4: **Dana Blair Field**
One person suggested this name.

Dana Blair (Class of 74) was a teacher and coach at Columbia River High School. Dana Blair taught a variety of subjects from typing to Health/PE. She coached women's volleyball, softball and bowling, winning state championships as head volleyball coach ('91), assistant softball coach (1996 and 1997) and academic state championship bowling (2008 and 2009).

CRHS Naming Committee Members:

Dave Bennett, athletic director, VPS; Columbia River Class of ‘83
Nick Davies, associate principal/athletic director, Columbia River High School
Tom Hagley, chief communications and public engagement officer, VPS; parent of a current Columbia River student (third-generation Columbia River family)
Tony Liberatore, associate principal, Fort Vancouver High School; Columbia River Class of ‘89
Darby Mead, principal, Vancouver iTech Preparatory; Columbia River Class of ‘96
Alex Otoupal, principal, Columbia River High School
Greg Roberts, associate principal/athletic director, Hudson’s Bay High School; Columbia River Class of ‘99
Brett Smedley, head football coach/teacher, Columbia River High School; Columbia River Class of ‘03
Tyler Stanley, dean of students, McLoughlin Middle School; Columbia River Class of ‘04
Shirly Valeos, retired teacher and coach, Columbia River High School 1967-2000
Mindy Williams-Cleeland, teacher, Skyview High School; Columbia River Class of ‘92

Current Students:
Satchel Baskette, Class of ‘25
Diego Carrion, Class of ‘25
Lukas Otoupal, Class of ‘25
Kaden Tschida, Class of ‘24